

# Farnsworth Court due-diligence report

## Executive view

The strongest public evidence currently available points to Farnsworth Court being an **early-2000s mid-rise block with a likely concrete primary structure and a system-built external envelope**, rather than a flimsy lightweight building. The reason I say “likely” is that I did not find an original structural frame drawing for the block itself, but the wider scheme’s engineering write-up states that apartment blocks above five storeys at this development were built with **in-situ concrete frames carrying attached cladding panels**, and Farnsworth Court is recorded in the 2025 fire statement as **20.0 metres high, 9 storeys, with no basement**. <sup>1</sup>

The main caution is **not obviously the main frame**. It is the **external wall build-up and associated fire remediation history**. The 2025 planning and fire documents show that the block’s timber cladding, terracotta-cladding build-up, balcony decking, brise soleil, and some spandrel/backing components all required remediation or further fire-stopping to meet current fire-safety expectations, with new materials required to achieve **A2-s1,d0 or better** and cavity barriers inserted at compartment lines and around openings. That is a meaningful negative from a purchaser’s point of view: it tells you the original envelope/specification is **not something to treat as “best in class by today’s standards”**, even if the building’s overall design was ambitious for its era. <sup>2</sup>

On the services side, the evidence points to **community heating and hot water**, not individual in-flat boilers, and to **double glazing** and **insulated system-built walls** in EPC-derived records for several Farnsworth flats. I found **no public proof that Farnsworth has MVHR**, and the fire statement instead describes **mechanical or natural smoke ventilation to protected corridors**, which is a different thing entirely. Exact insulation thicknesses, ceiling heights, slab/party-wall details, and plumbing schematics were **not disclosed in the public material I could verify**. <sup>3</sup>

## What the public record clearly shows

The most important current document set is the 2025 cladding-remediation application submitted to Royal Borough of Greenwich <sup>4</sup> for works to Farnsworth Court and the neighbouring block within Greenwich Millennium Village <sup>5</sup>. The application is recorded under **24/3776/F** and describes the works as the **removal and replacement of combustible materials and build-ups in the existing external cladding materials**. The accompanying fire statement says the project arises from **FRAEW assessments under PAS 9980**, and that the principle of the work is to remove combustible external-wall and attachment materials and replace them with materials with a reaction-to-fire classification of at least **Class A2-s1,d0**. <sup>6</sup>

The same fire statement gives the clearest basic building facts I found for Farnsworth Court itself: **20.0m building height, 9 storeys ground and above, no basement**, and residential use as **flats, maisonettes and studios**. It also states that the remedial works **do not alter the building’s internal arrangement**. <sup>7</sup>

The fire strategy is also explicit about what Farnsworth does **not** have. Each block/core is said to rely on **a single escape stair**, reached from flat entrance doors via **protected corridors with mechanical or**

**natural smoke ventilation**, and the report says the buildings **do not have automatic fire suppression** because sprinklers were not required by the guidance in force when they were built. From a purchaser's perspective, that means this is **not** a later-generation London apartment block with the more modern package of sprinklers plus clearly documented whole-dwelling MVHR. <sup>7</sup>

A 2017 scheme exhibition by the developer says phases 1 and 2 of the wider estate were built between **2002 and 2009**, and a later heat-network operator note says the **existing phases 1 and 2 heat network** was also originally built between **2000 and 2009**. That dating matters because it places Farnsworth Court in the period before today's building-safety rules, before the current external-wall regime, and before MVHR became common in many London flats. <sup>8</sup>

## What can be reconstructed about the structure and envelope

The most useful public technical clue about the structure is an engineering article on the wider estate that says **blocks up to 5 storeys** were built from metal and timber panels without an independent frame, whereas **blocks above that height** used an **in-situ concrete frame with cladding panels attached**. Because Farnsworth Court is recorded at **9 storeys / 20m**, the safest reading is that it is **probably a concrete-framed building with non-loadbearing façade systems**. I would treat this as a well-supported inference, not a formally proven as-built fact. <sup>1</sup>

The façade composition is much clearer. The 2025 design-and-access statement prepared by Jefferson Sheard Architects <sup>9</sup> says Farnsworth Court's existing external materials comprise **Wall Type 17 timber panel windows, Wall Type 22 render, Wall Type 23 timber cladding, and Wall Type 24 terracotta**, and describes the two south-side blocks as having an **expressed galvanised steel structure and extensive brise soleil**. The same statement says the combustible items needing replacement are the **timber cladding, terracotta cladding build-up/substrate, decking and brise soleil**. <sup>10</sup>

The fire-remediation scope, derived from FRAEW reports by Ashton Fire <sup>11</sup>, is more revealing than most sales literature ever is. For Farnsworth Court it requires: removal of timber cladding and balcony timber-cladding surrounds; cavity barriers at **all compartment lines** and **all openings** between the render carrier board and new cladding; cavity barriers between the **sheathing board** and the back of the terracotta tiles; replacement of **plywood** behind aluminium spandrel panels with A2 material and cavity barriers at compartment-floor level; replacement of timber balcony decking; and replacement of timber brise soleil where vertically aligned over more than two storeys. That tells you the existing façade is a **multi-layer system** with carrier boards, sheathing boards, spandrel backing and ventilated cavities, not a simple brick wall. <sup>12</sup>

The approved replacement product palette is also stated. The application proposes **Argeton Tampa terracotta cladding, Cedral Click Brick Red fibre-cement cladding, Ryno Balca-Smart aluminium decking in Quartz Grey / RAL 7039, and bespoke raw aluminium brise soleil**. The Cedral datasheet appended to the planning package gives a thickness of **12mm**, an **A2-s1,d0** reaction-to-fire classification, and a declared thermal conductivity of **0.212 W/mK** for the cladding board itself. The Argeton terracotta literature describes the system as a **rear-ventilated ceramic façade** with a non-combustible ceramic outer layer and **free choice of insulation thickness** behind it. What it does **not** disclose is the **actual insulation type or thickness chosen for Farnsworth Court**, so that crucial point remains unresolved in the public record. <sup>13</sup>

That absence matters. If you are trying to judge long-term thermal or condensation performance, the public planning set is strong on **fire classification and façade replacement products**, but weak on **U-**

**values, insulation depth, vapour control strategy, thermal-bridge treatment, acoustic build-up, and exact cavity geometry.** Those are exactly the things a cautious buyer would still want to see in as-built/O&M documentation. <sup>14</sup>

## Heating, ventilation and other services

The best available evidence on heat and hot water comes from two directions. First, the estate-wide heat-network material says the **existing phases 1 and 2 network serves over a thousand homes** and provides **heating and hot water**, but that the plant and energy-centre matrix had become **out-dated and difficult to maintain**, prompting a retrofit/operations programme by Switch2 Energy <sup>15</sup>. Second, multiple EPC-derived records for individual Farnsworth flats describe **community-scheme heating, community-scheme hot water**, and in several cases **CHP/community mains gas** as the main fuel arrangement. Put together, that is strong evidence that Farnsworth is on a **central/community heat network**, not on individual flat boilers. <sup>16</sup>

The same EPC-derived records repeatedly describe the flats' walls as **"system built, as built, insulated (assumed)"** and the windows as **"fully double glazed"**. I am deliberately treating that as **strong but secondary evidence**, because the official EPC PDFs themselves were not retrievable in this session; what I could see were multiple mirrors of the government data. Still, the consistency across several flats is useful: it strongly suggests insulated system-built external walls and double glazing are normal at Farnsworth Court. <sup>17</sup>

Ventilation is more uncertain. I found **no public document confirming MVHR in Farnsworth Court**. The fire statement only confirms **smoke ventilation** to common protected corridors, and later-phase Greenwich Millennium Village planning material explicitly refers to **MVHR** in newer buildings. That contrast is important: if later phases say "MVHR" in black and white but the early-2000s Farnsworth documents do not, the prudent assumption is **do not assume MVHR is present** unless the seller or managing agent produces original M&E/O&M information proving it. <sup>18</sup>

On plumbing and public-health services, the public record is thin. The heat-network evidence makes centralised heating/hot-water distribution clear, but I did **not** find publicly available riser diagrams, domestic water schematics, drainage stacks, sanitaryware specifications, or plant schedules for Farnsworth Court itself. That is a real limitation if you are trying to assess leak risk, access for maintenance, or the quality of the original services installation. The one clear caution flag is that the phase 1–2 heat-network operator itself describes the old estate plant as **ageing and hard to maintain**, so services risk should be part of your due diligence, not an afterthought. <sup>19</sup>

## Layout, windows and dimensions

The 2025 planning documents are about façade remediation, so they do **not** give a detailed buyer-friendly set of apartment plans. They explicitly say the proposals do not change **amount, layout or scale**, and the fire statement says internal arrangements remain unchanged, but they do not disclose apartment-by-apartment room layouts in an easily accessible public form. <sup>20</sup>

What I could find on layout comes mostly from sales and letting particulars, so it should be treated as **indicative rather than engineering-grade evidence**. Those particulars repeatedly describe Farnsworth flats as having **open-plan kitchen/living spaces, balconies, 1-, 2- and 3-bedroom layouts**, utility/storage areas, and **large or floor-to-ceiling windows**. Examples I found include an **825 sq ft** two-bed flat with open-plan living/kitchen and balcony, a **650 sq ft** one-bed flat with floor-to-ceiling living-

room windows, and a **1,278 sq ft** penthouse with a 48-foot open-plan living area and a variety of floor-to-ceiling windows. <sup>21</sup>

Windows are one of the better-supported features. The façade documents refer to **timber panel windows** as one of the wall types, while the EPC-derived records repeatedly describe individual flats as **fully double glazed**. The most reasonable reading is that Farnsworth uses a system-built façade with window zones/panels integrated into the overall cladding composition, and that the flats themselves generally have double-glazed window units. <sup>22</sup>

Ceiling height is the notable gap. I did **not** find a verified technical document giving Farnsworth Court's clear internal floor-to-ceiling height. Sales material often mentions **floor-to-ceiling windows**, but that is not the same thing as a measured ceiling-height schedule. If ceiling height matters to you, this is something to demand in the leasehold sales pack or by viewing an as-built drawing/O&M set rather than assuming from marketing language. <sup>23</sup>

## What this means for build quality and future risk

The wider estate was unquestionably conceived as an ambitious sustainability-led development. Contemporary and retrospective scheme material describes passive-solar orientation, large south-facing glazing, external shading via balconies/canopies, high-grade insulation, efficient appliances and cogeneration/community energy. In other words, Farnsworth Court sits within a project that started with **good environmental intentions and stronger-than-average urban-design thinking** for its period. <sup>24</sup>

But ambitious concept and dependable technical delivery are not the same thing. The fact that Farnsworth Court now needs a substantial external-wall remediation package tells you that the original envelope included **combustible materials and/or insufficient fire-stopping details** that do not satisfy present expectations. The required remedial works are not trivial cosmetic changes: they include reworking cladding layers, cavity barriers, spandrel build-ups, balcony decking and brise soleil. That is a serious legacy defect pattern, even if the underlying structure may still be perfectly robust. <sup>25</sup>

So my overall judgement is this: **not obviously a low-standard building in structural terms, but certainly not a carefree "premium modern spec" purchase either**. The positives are likely concrete-frame robustness, double glazing, central heat/hot water, generous glazing, balconies, and an originally strong sustainability brief. The negatives are the known façade-remediation history, the lack of evidenced MVHR, the absence of sprinklers, the ageing phase 1–2 heat network, and the lack of publicly visible as-built information on insulation depth, plumbing and acoustic/internal build-ups. In plain English: I would worry **more about envelope, fire-compliance history, future service-charge pressure and services ageing** than about basic collapse/structural integrity. <sup>26</sup>

## Open questions and documents to demand before exchange

Several of the most buyer-relevant questions remain unresolved in the public domain. I did **not** find a verified public record of the original insulation specification, exact ceiling heights, as-built floor/wall acoustic build-ups, public-health/plumbing schematics, or a publicly visible completion certificate bundle for the building. The cladding/remediation package also implies additional sign-off by bodies including building control, the fire engineer and NHBC <sup>27</sup>, but I did not locate those sign-off documents themselves. <sup>28</sup>

Before exchange, I would insist on seeing the following documents, not just verbal reassurance:

- The **latest EWS1**, the **FRAEW executive summary**, and the **full scope/completion status** of the Farnsworth Court remediation works, including whether your flat is directly affected and whether any costs remain to be recovered through the service charge. The planning documents prove that significant remediation was required; they do not prove that it is finished. <sup>29</sup>
- The **post-remediation sign-off trail**: planning discharge/decision, building-control approval or completion paperwork, fire-engineer sign-off, and any warranty-provider correspondence. The construction logistics plan specifically envisages sign-off from building control, the fire engineer and NHBC. <sup>28</sup>
- The **heat-network information pack**: current operator, recent outages, tariff method, retrofit timetable, plant replacement plans, and the last 2–3 years of service-charge budgets/accounts. The estate heat network serving phases 1 and 2 has been described publicly as old and difficult to maintain. <sup>19</sup>
- If available, the **O&M manuals / as-built services drawings / façade details** for your block or core, because the public planning set is good on fire remediation but poor on the buyer questions people actually live with day to day: insulation depth, ventilation type, condensate risk, pipework access, spandrel details, and acoustic separation. <sup>14</sup>

If those documents come back clean, Farnsworth Court could still be a sensible purchase: the evidence suggests a serious but defined **envelope remediation problem**, not a fundamentally disposable building. If those documents are missing, vague, or disputed, I would treat that as a warning sign, because the main uncertainties left in this research are exactly the ones that can generate future cost and management pain. <sup>30</sup>

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<sup>1</sup> <sup>26</sup> <https://www.ingenia.org.uk/articles/homes-for-the-new-millennium-new-technology-and-innovation-at-greenwich-millennium-village/>

<https://www.ingenia.org.uk/articles/homes-for-the-new-millennium-new-technology-and-innovation-at-greenwich-millennium-village/>

<sup>2</sup> <sup>10</sup> <sup>13</sup> <sup>20</sup> <sup>22</sup> <sup>27</sup> [https://docs.planning.org.uk/20250106/53/\\_GRNW\\_DCAPR\\_122658/7wk0fm0nsylmv83s.pdf](https://docs.planning.org.uk/20250106/53/_GRNW_DCAPR_122658/7wk0fm0nsylmv83s.pdf)

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<sup>3</sup> <sup>9</sup> <sup>17</sup> <https://housemetric.co.uk/19164602/SE10-0QG/Flat%2B32%2BFarnsworth%2BCourt%2BWest%2BParkside>

<https://housemetric.co.uk/19164602/SE10-0QG/Flat%2B32%2BFarnsworth%2BCourt%2BWest%2BParkside>

<sup>4</sup> <sup>11</sup> <sup>12</sup> <sup>14</sup> <sup>15</sup> <sup>25</sup> <sup>28</sup> <sup>30</sup> [https://docs.planning.org.uk/20250106/53/\\_GRNW\\_DCAPR\\_122658/j823u3q7ui5srt8q.pdf](https://docs.planning.org.uk/20250106/53/_GRNW_DCAPR_122658/j823u3q7ui5srt8q.pdf)

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<sup>5</sup> <sup>7</sup> <sup>18</sup> <sup>29</sup> [https://docs.planning.org.uk/20250106/53/\\_GRNW\\_DCAPR\\_122658/6g20jnpwtuqxjhuo.pdf](https://docs.planning.org.uk/20250106/53/_GRNW_DCAPR_122658/6g20jnpwtuqxjhuo.pdf)

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<sup>6</sup> [https://www.royalgreenwich.gov.uk/sites/default/files/2025-08/Planning\\_Applications\\_06\\_to\\_10\\_January\\_2025.pdf](https://www.royalgreenwich.gov.uk/sites/default/files/2025-08/Planning_Applications_06_to_10_January_2025.pdf)

[https://www.royalgreenwich.gov.uk/sites/default/files/2025-08/Planning\\_Applications\\_06\\_to\\_10\\_January\\_2025.pdf](https://www.royalgreenwich.gov.uk/sites/default/files/2025-08/Planning_Applications_06_to_10_January_2025.pdf)

<sup>8</sup> <https://www.greenwichmillenniumvillage.co.uk/files/COnsultation/7th-9th-february-2017.pdf?c263fbe412=>

<https://www.greenwichmillenniumvillage.co.uk/files/COnsultation/7th-9th-february-2017.pdf?c263fbe412=>

<sup>16</sup> <sup>19</sup> <https://switch2.co.uk/greenwich-millennium-village-awards-30-year-heat-network-contract-to-switch2-energy/>

<https://switch2.co.uk/greenwich-millennium-village-awards-30-year-heat-network-contract-to-switch2-energy/>

<sup>21</sup> <https://media.onthemarket.com/properties/7128924/1017288558/document-0.pdf>

<https://media.onthemarket.com/properties/7128924/1017288558/document-0.pdf>

<sup>23</sup> <https://www.openrent.co.uk/property-to-rent/london/1-bed-flat-farnsworth-court-se10/2543474>

<https://www.openrent.co.uk/property-to-rent/london/1-bed-flat-farnsworth-court-se10/2543474>

<sup>24</sup> <https://casestudies.uli.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/12/C036003.pdf>

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